

SPREADING THE SPREADS

For many, the spreadsheet might just be a replacement for a calculator, but if you want, you can really do some amazing statistical stuff, generate fabulous reports and charts, or create complicated tables.

Formatting

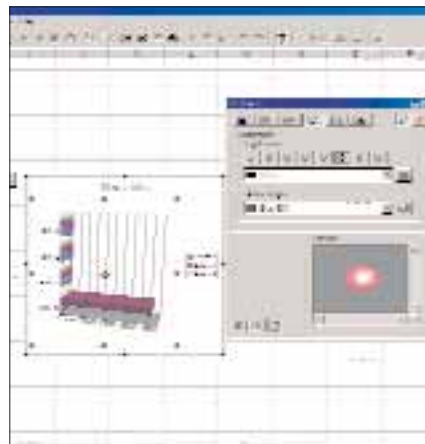
Working with cells and cell properties can be really crazy at times. Take StarOffice Calc for example. Here, every time you press the [Delete] key to remove the contents of a cell, you get a confirmation box asking whether you want to delete the values, the formatting, the formulas, etc, which can get a bit irritating. It's a nice feature if you are using a number of calculations and want to keep the value but delete the formula. There's a workaround by using the [Shift] + [Delete] key, but it's not the best of methods. 602Tab, like its word processor, is quite basic and you cannot merge cells if you want, nor can you experiment with any text orientation.

Lotus 1-2-3 is quite good in that respect and gives you a number of text orientation features that can be quite useful if you are creating a spreadsheet in portrait mode with a number of columns but limited rows. In 1-2-3, every cell is taken to be a range, and therefore you have to work with range properties for aspects such as merging or splitting cells. You could also create text blocks, which may help if you want to mix text along with cells. It also comes with a neat handle that lets you move the cell contents along.

We found Excel still problematic when it comes to copy-pasting cells. Copy a cell's contents from the cell instead of the status bar, perform a number of operations, and

then try to paste the contents, and you will find that Excel has lost the copied data from the system clipboard. The same data is still available in the Office clipboard and you can retrieve it from there, but that's a tedious thing to do.

1-2-3 and Excel 2002 were the only ones that had Indian currency also in the list, although it was listed as INR (the global notation) and not rupees. In Excel, the currency list was sorted by just the global notation, whereas 1-2-3 had the country name also, thus making life easier for you.



Enjoy the 3D effects in StarOffice

Calculations

All the spreadsheet packages except 602Tab were intuitive when it came to the automatic sum option. They assumed that the cells above or by the side are what you want to work with. No such luck with 602Tab. Excel 2002 has added to the list in the Auto Sum option. You now have a drop-down list that features other variables such as Average.

StarOffice Calc and Excel 2002 came with options to trace errors. StarOffice Calc calls it the Detective option. This feature allows you to trace the dependencies to a formula. Excel 2002 has the Formula Audit feature that traces dependencies as well as precedents for each cell.

These features are useful if you work with huge amounts of data, and have to resolve errors in formulae or instances of circular references.

An added function in Excel 2002 is the Watch Window feature that allows you to specify a cell that will be constantly watched even while you scroll across the sheet. The value of the cell is shown in the Watch Window, and you automatically come to know if any changes have been made to it.

Graphs

StarOffice Calc is simply the best when it comes to graphs. Because of its tight integration with the drawing tools, you can have a variety of graphs and apply gradients and transparency, apart from a whole lot of 3D effects such as specifying material source, the geometry of the image, lighting and texture. With 1-2-3 and Excel 2002, you just had the standard 2D and 3D variants and you add some shadows and gradients.

Macros and Forms

If you are looking at performing a series of similar calculations over a range of similar cells, using a macro might be a good idea. With StarOffice Calc and Excel 2002, creating this is quite simple—just use the record button. In 1-2-3, the macros options are hidden under the Edit menu. Creation of forms and drop-down lists without any use of scripts is only possible in Excel 2002. 1-2-3 also allows you to do the same, though you have to learn the Lotus Scripting language for this.

On the whole, 1-2-3 still maintains the simplicity that it's known for, but this is at the cost of features. Most of the features that you normally need are present in this software, but advanced features such as provision for pivot tables and reporting tools are missing. Even StarOffice Calc suffers from the same problem, though it is great for graphs.

Excel 2002 scores over the other contenders because of its feature-list and increased ease of use with the Smart Tags and Task Pane (try to fill a numbered series and see how the Smart Tags help you).

Analysing your Data

The spreadsheet utilities come with some extra features that are normally quite useful for analysing data in a statistical manner. If you are into sales and marketing, then goal-seek, scenario builder or trend analysis is exactly what you are looking for. 1-2-3 comes with a 'What-if' feature where you can see and analyse changes in projections that get reflected with differing data.

Excel allows you to create different scenarios or specify a goal and work backward towards attaining the goal. Getting a grouped data analysis is much

simpler with the Pivot Table and Pivot Chart option. StarOffice too has the goal-seek option. Other advanced features that you will find in these suites are options for validating data and grouping, sorting and consolidating data. Strangely enough, in 1-2-3, some of the more analytical, statistical functions such as the cross-tabs and quick reports are inserted as a link to the database component (Lotus Approach), while other tools like matrix and inverse matrix that are normally used only by mathematicians are present as a feature.